



Industry News

Vietnam government opts for FOSS

According to a report by VietnamNet [english.vietnamnet.vn/tech/2009/01/822425], Vietnam's minister of information and communications has issued an instruction for IT workers of government agencies to switch to open source software. As per the report, "...by June 30, 2009, 100 per cent of the clients of the IT divisions of government agencies must be installed with open source software; 100 per cent of staff members at these IT divisions must be trained in the use of these software products and at least 50 per cent use them proficiently."

Some of the software specifically suggested in the news report are OpenOffice.org as the office suite, Thunderbird for e-mailing, Firefox for Web browsing, and a Vietnamese typing software called Unikey.

In addition, the state agencies have been asked to "increase the number of documents and information exchanged among them that are processed by the above software," with a directive that all staff at these agencies must be able to use FOSS at work by December 31, 2010. The minister has even instructed the PC vendors to install open source software, rather than 'cracked' software, on the systems they sell.



Qt to have LGPL option too

Nokia has announced that its Qt cross-platform user interface and application framework for desktop and embedded platforms will be available under the Lesser General Public License (LGPL) version 2.1 from the release of Qt 4.5, scheduled for March 2009. Previously, Qt has been made available to the open source community under the General Public License (GPL).

The move to LGPL will provide open source and commercial developers with more permissive licensing than GPL and so increase flexibility for developers. In addition, Qt source code repositories will be made publicly available and will encourage contributions from desktop and embedded developer communities. With these changes, developers will be able to actively drive the evolution of the Qt framework.

Qt 4.5 will also be available under commercial licensing terms, while licensing for previous versions of Qt remains unchanged. In addition, service offerings for Qt will be expanded to ensure that all Qt development projects can have access to the same levels of support, independent of the selected licence.

"Qt being available under the terms of the LGPL streamlines the licensing of applications built using KDE components on top of Qt-based applications," said Sebastian Kügler, KDE e.V. board member. "This more permissive licensing will further lower the barrier for adoption of Qt and KDE technologies. The KDE team welcomes opening up the development process and is looking forward to improved collaboration between KDE and Qt Software."

For more information visit qtsoftware.com/licensing.

Microsoft works late nights to enable Linux users?

With Barack Obama as the US president, it looks like a change has certainly come. According to a ZDNet.com report [blogs.zdnet.com/open-source/?p=3303] Microsoft apparently worked late night together with Novell's Mono and Moonlight developers on January 19 to enable Linux desktop users to view the US presidential inauguration on Moonlight—the open source alternative to Silverlight.

The US presidential inauguration committee apparently had chosen Silverlight to broadcast the inauguration events over the Internet on January 20. Considering the software only supports Windows and Mac, with the FOSS alternative Moonlight not ready yet to support the live Webcast (as initially admitted by Moonlight chief, Miguel de Icaza), it obviously attracted the flack of the Linux and other FOSS OS users.

However, a surprise came early on the morning of January 20. de Icaza wrote in his blog [tirania.org/blog/archive/2009/jan-20.html]: "I just wanted to confirm that you can watch today's Barack Obama Official Inauguration video stream using Moonlight on Linux/x86 and Linux/x86-64 systems. All you need to do is to go to the Moonlight Download page... Microsoft worked late night night to get us access to the code that will be used during the inauguration so we could test it with Moonlight."

Looks like the two are in fact working on interoperability. But wouldn't it have been better if pic2009.org had chosen a software/technology that's universally available so none of these issues would have cropped up at the final moments? Or at least, MS and Novell could have collaborated in advance to avoid keeping the FOSS OS users waiting till the last moment.